

CHANNELS OF BUSINESS COMMUNICATION:-

Communication channel is the medium or means through which the message sent by the sender travels to the receiver. For example in Television, you must be seeing and hearing different events on different channels. Channel combines audio signal with a video signal; together and they convey the message to the audience. In radio, channel has only audio signal. Similarly while speaking or writing, we use a channel to convey a message. Thus, television is an audio-video channel, whereas radio is only a audio channel.

There are other channels, such as telephone, voicemail, public address system, Invoice Internet Protocol (VoIP). There are only written channels, such as letters, memorandum, invoices, blogs, tweets, e-mails etc. The choice of the channel depends on type of communication , i.e. whether it is verbal or non-verbal; if it is verbal, whether it is face-to-face or audio, and if it is non-verbal, whether it is written in the form of hard or it is in the electronic form.

It also depends on the size of the business organization and areas of its operations; i.e. whether it is big or small, national or multinational. Depending on all these factors various types of channels are available. The Information Technology has made various channels and communication platforms available depending on the need of the business organization. An appropriate channel for communication can be selected. The choice of the channel in business communication has important ramifications, because if a proper channel is not selected and the message is not delivered in time or it is delivered in a distorted form, business organisation may suffer not only financial losses, its corporate image may also be blurred. In this unit, you will learn the factors influencing choice of a channel and classification of channels.

FACTORS INFLUENCING COMMUNICATION CHANNELS

The following factors help in choosing a channel for the communication:

(i)The nature of message: Before choosing a channel, it is utmost important to critically assess the nature of the message. In this context, think over the following points:

- Is the message formal or informal?
- Is it necessary to keep a record of the message for future reference?
- Is it urgent?
- Is it confidential or sensitive?
- Is it general or specific?
- Is it for an individual or a group?
- Is the individual a peer, a higher-up, or someone you lead?
- Is it for your team or the whole company?
- Is it one-way or two-way communication, i.e. is a response expected?

After considering the above factors, it becomes easy to choose a channel. For example, a formal business communication whose reference may be required in future and whose response is required, should be sent through a verbal channel preferably in the written form. But in case, it is urgent also, an electronic mail (e-

mail) may be better. If it is not formal, but is urgent, a Whatsapp message can be sent or a telephonic talk will also be ok.

Another example may be cited here: a marketing personnel of the company is negotiating the price of an instrument with a buyer, who is insisting on a price lower than the quoted price, for clinching the deal, marketing personnel needs a nod from his manager. Therefore, he would like to provide detailed information to his manager. At the same time, he would require feedback from the manager for further negotiations. In such a case, a video-chat may be preferred. In case it is confidential and is for one person, a telephonic conversation will be most appropriate.

(ii) Purpose of the message: While considering purpose of the communication, following factors should be considered

- Is it for motivation?
- Is it for sharing of information?
- Is it for socialisation?
 - Is to control your subordinates?
- Is it for the training of the staff?
- Is it for placing an order for the grocery?

After considering these points, one may choose an appropriate channel. For example, if it is for the motivation or for the training of the staff, a face-face channel, such as audio-video channel would be preferred. In case it is just for sharing an information, a telephonic conversation may be preferred. But if an order is to be placed for a pizza or grocery, an app of the concerned supplier may be used through smartphone.

(iii) Is the interaction with the receiver required?

If yes, face to face channel will be better. For this purpose, Whatsapp or Skype can be used.

(iv) Is it about showing some features of device? In this case, visual aids will be helpful to impress upon the recipient of the message. As described in the previous unit, in recent years, several such channels including Artificial Intelligence, Googl's Duplex. Blockchain, Augmented Reality (AR) and Virtual Reality (VR) Technologies, Internet of Things (IoT) Technology and LiFi Technology have been developed. .

(v) Size of audience: It is one person or a small group or a large audience. As mentioned earlier, for one to one interaction, channels such as telephone, Whatsapp, Skype can be used. But if the message is for a mass, audio-visual channel is preferred.

(vi) Background of the audience: It is very important factor in choosing the channel. Is it a group of managers, or subordinates or teammates? Are they well informed about your products or you are going to introduce your products for the

first time? Are they of urban background or from rural background? For a meeting of the managers where you are going to discuss company's progress and achievements, audio-visual channel would be preferred where you can explain your points with the help of graphs, bar diagrams, etc. When you are making publicity of your products particularly in the rural area, a channel such as Power Point will be most appropriate where you can show attractive slides of your products including their popularity in the urban areas.